

Vertigo



(Photo by Peter Laurensen : Cloudy Peak www.occasionalclimber.co.nz)

Newsletter of the New Zealand Alpine Club - Wellington Section
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Section News

Section Nights

At our May section night, Dan Joll gave us some interesting insights into climbing overseas especially in the Chamanoix area of France. Inspiration for some of us and the trigger for one of this month's articles in Vertigo.

We're skipping section night in June as it's BANFF month and the committee will be flat out making those sessions a reality for you all. We have two programmes of movies for you again this year and two opportunities to see each programme. Further details on BANFF 2016 can be found later in Vertigo.

In July, we'll be running our annual avalanche awareness evening, led by our in-house expert, Aviette. This will be at our usual haunt at the Southern Cross from 6pm on Wednesday 6 July. Before heading up into the snow this winter come along and learn about avalanche safety (and avoidance!).

Come along, invite your friends and grab a drink from the bar – there'll be time for a catch up and chat after the meeting.

Chair's Report

Ahh, the brisk morning air of a southerly and the scent of snow! Great stuff unless you're unlucky enough to be on the Wanaka side of the Crown Range and no one tells you the road is closed on the Queenstown side because vehicles are sliding off it (but not on the Wanaka side). Perhaps there is a difference between Queenstown and Wanaka drivers or could it be the other way around?

And now for something completely different. That's right it's Banff Banff Banff wonderful Banff! We only just mentioned it at the last section night and already over a third of the tickets are gone for the four film festival showings. That might be great news for some but it doesn't bode well for late risers - if it's anything like last year we sold out all four sessions – just saying. Don't forget that there is no section night in June due to Banff. Please pass this on to any non members you know.

Snow craft courses are going the same way with the first course already fully booked and a growing wait list and the second and third filling fast. At the rate we are going we may need to take it down from the website.

If you follow the inner workings of the NZAC closely you might also know that we have a new general manager – Keith Gilby. He is keen to meet as many members as he can and is planning to come up for the opening night of Banff. I haven't met him yet but based on a few phone conversations he sounds like a reasonable sort of chap and apparently reliable on the end of a rope

Simon

For quick access to the section’s page on the NZAC website, scan the below QR code.



Upcoming Trips, Courses and Events

BANFF



Paramount, Courtenay Place June 7, 16, 19 and 22

June marks the month we've all been waiting for – it's BANFF time! As most of you will know, these screenings are super popular here in Wellington and each year we sell out. Ticket sales are already heating up so get in quick to avoid disappointment.

We have two programmes screening at Paramount with two opportunities to see each programme. Programme A is screening from 6pm on Tuesday 7 June and again from 1pm Sunday 19 June. Programme B is screening from 6pm on Thursday 16 June with the second screening from 6pm on Wednesday 22 June.

For information about the movies in each programme click [here](#) or to get ticket information and a link to buy tickets click [here](#).

Wellington Section Trips

The following is the last trip that is currently being planned by the committee. The section continues to subsidise rental vehicles for the South Island trips to make the trips more affordable. Keep an eye on our Facebook page for more details or email us on wellington@alpineclub.org.nz to let us know if you're keen to come along. Also, please contact us if you're keen to run a trip yourself – the committee can help with advertising / logistics.

When?	Where?
Queen's Birthday Weekend	Seaward Kaikouras

Wellington Section Snowcraft courses

Beginner course:

- moving on snow using ice axe and crampons

- evaluating terrain for safe travel
- navigation
- avalanche transceiver use

This course focuses on taking participants new to mountaineering into the mountains to gain skills, confidence and experience in the alpine environment. It requires good fitness and caters to those with little or no experience on snow or ice. It involves learning the basics of moving around in alpine terrain safely, using an ice axe and crampons, identifying terrain hazards and basic emergency procedures. It does not include ropes. It assumes prior knowledge of tramping and self management in a remote environment. It does not assume prior knowledge of alpine skills.

Intermediate course:

- using ropes & snow anchors

This course builds on the competencies of a beginner, adding rope, anchors and belays and single pitch climbing. The course assumes prior knowledge of core snow craft skills such as cramponing, transceiver searches, ice axe use and self management in a remote alpine environment.

Advanced course:

- pitching and travel

This course focuses on consolidation of the skills covered in the beginner and intermediate courses and applying them to pitched climbing and travel in an alpine environment.

Course Dates

22-24 July (pre-course evening 14 July); split Beginner and Intermediate course - this course is currently full, let us know if you'd like to be added to the wait list.

12-24 August (pre-course evening 4 August) split Beginner and Intermediate course.

26-28 August (pre-course evening 18 August) Advanced course.

All pre-course evenings are in Wellington at Bivouac on the Thursday night a week prior at 6pm.

We've moved the location of this winter's courses to the Whakapapa side of the mountain and will be staying at the Manawatu Lodge. Course fees cover accommodation for two nights and main meals. The section provides selected equipment for hire (except boots, clothing and personal items) for \$5 an item per 7 days.

The course fee has increased slightly this year and has been set at \$270. You need to be a member of the NZAC to attend our snowcraft courses. See <http://alpineclub.org.nz/apply-for-membership/> for details on how to signup to the NZAC. There is a \$100 deposit payable on registration with final payment due 2 weeks before the course commences. Payments are refundable up to a week prior to the start date of the course after which the deposit is forfeited.

Registration forms are available on Facebook and on our section page of the NZAC website.

Trip Reports

Plan C – Southwest Ridge of Cloudy Peak

Peter Laurensen

Despite the record breaking sunshine hours in the first part of 2016, our third nominated weekend to make an attempt on Sefton from Welcome Pass again had to be binned due to bad weather. It looked better off the main divide though, so my Christchurch based climbing buddies Piotr Nowak, James Hobson and I planned to take a look at Kitchener and Annette – Plan B. By the time I reached Christchurch however, even Plan B looked no good as the fickle weather forecast deteriorated further.



Cloudy Peak (2,403m) is right, with part of the southwest ridge on the right skyline

Hmmm, something even further east, starting with C, for Plan C – how about Cloudy Peak?! I'd never heard of it, but my Cantabrian colleagues, unlike me both very capable rock climbers, reckoned the southwest ridge of Cloudy Peak would give us a nice challenge. The trouble with Plan C's is that you really have to wing it - any pre-climb prep time has been expended on plans A and B. This set us up for a couple of surprises.

Our dawn departure from Christchurch in James' Landcruiser was timed so we could reach our bivvy beneath Cloudy Peak before nightfall. About two hours' drive got us to Erewhon Station, located in magnificent high country, also at the site of Edoras (of Lord of the Rings fame). From there James' unfeasibly chunky tyres came into their own as we jolted our way across the mouth of the Clyde River into the Havelock. Due to the need to route find on our first foray this way, it took about an hour to reach our parking point. James doesn't muck about though, so our return two days later only took half an hour.

Going by the map, reaching Cloudy Peak looks like just a short scramble up Cloudy Stream, gaining about 600 metres. But maps can be deceiving. In reality, access to the stream bed is via a shelf on the true left of the stream. This takes you up through tussock to about 900 metres, at

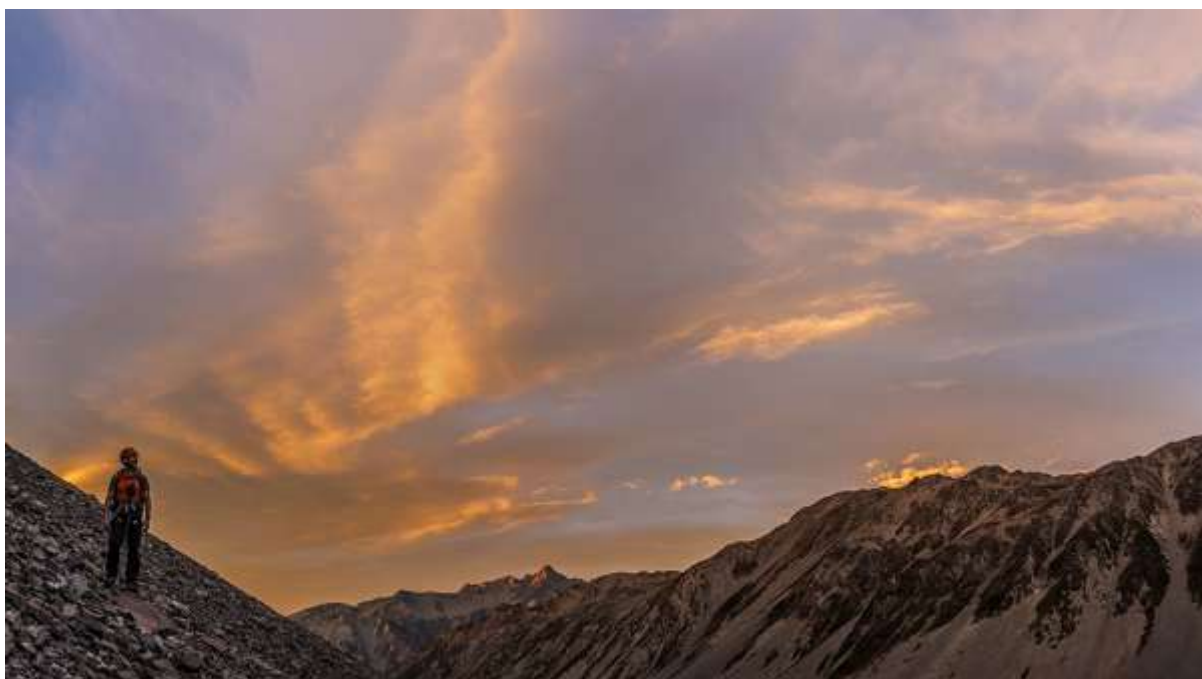
which point you could be forgiven for thinking that another hour or so of easy hiking will see you at the bivvy.

Wrong – surprise number one. It's at this point, as you swing round into the valley that the going becomes more unruly. For the next three hours we shoved and stumbled through thick scrub and Manuka and across boulder fields, all the while trying to stick to some trace of a route, which is scanty to say the least.



West face of Cloudy Peak, seen from our rock bivvy. The southwest ridge again on the skyline, centre

Eventually we reached the bivvy at 1,280 metres, fit to house three at a squeeze, once all the Thar droppings had been excavated. Surprise number two – no water. On account of the huge boulder piles, Cloudy Stream is buried between about 1,050 and 1,400 metres. After some discussion and the drawing of straws we elected to go up further to the base of a waterfall to get our supply – easier to carry down than up and the thought of retracing our steps down through all those boulders held zero appeal. In the late afternoon light at least the view from beneath the waterfall, back down Cloudy Stream across to the Two Thumb Range, was worth the effort.



Enjoying dawn light on the Two Thumb range



Above, nearing the base of the southwest ridge. Below, Piotr leading the first pitch



The night was crystal clear, so I elected to bivvy out, watching the stars roll by. Next morning, in still calm but clouding skies, we set off at dawn up the scree to the base of the southwest ridge at about 1,500 metres. Our intended route is graded 3, 15 so, not having done much rock climbing, I was excited to see just how difficult this would be. As I watched Piotr lead the first pitch up near vertical rock, battling his way around a small roof, I started to wonder if I was even going to be able to follow him with the benefit of a top rope.

I was in good hands though, with Piotr and James alternating lead and tail end Charlie, while I struggled and cursed my way upward. To be fair, we climbed in mountain boots, not rock shoes, which certainly made things trickier. And according to Piotr and James, there were some points on the route that exceeded grade 15. Whatever the grade, it was more difficult than anything I'd previously climbed and good to know now where my limits lie.

Following Piotr's first pitch, James led on up a second steep section before we reached an exposed shoulder. Although we kept the rope on, this section was free-climbable. It led to a second near vertical section, requiring another rope length, before we reached some steep sloping scree on a ledge. Looming above was a huge wall and it wasn't at all apparent where the southwest ridge route went next. In hindsight, we probably traversed too far left across the scree, ending up on the near vertical west face.



Above and below, James on our last pitch. This face would have required at least three pitches to regain the ridgeline



We were at 1,800 metres – only 300 metres into a 900 metre climb; and it was already after 2pm. As I munched on some lunch I pondered what Queenstown-based Dave McLeod and his climbing buddy's had achieved many years ago on the first winter ascent of the southwest ridge. They had not only completed it in mountain boots and crampons, but also walked in and out from Erewhon Station, all in just two huge days. Respect!

Although it now seemed likely that we'd be benighted if we continued, James was keen to keep going. So he led up a groove that seemed to have plenty of holds. This was the case, but putting in solid protection was another matter. He retreated and tried another line, running the rope up about 30 metres before Piotr and I made the call that there was no way we could reach the top before nightfall. Even then, James' anchor placement skills were tested to place anything close to a bulletproof abseil point. By the time he re-joined us on the scree it was 4pm.

Two abseils later saw us back on the main scree fan giving access to the free-climbable east side of Cloudy Peak. Unfortunately, with less than an hour of daylight left, the 800 or so vertical metres of scrambling to the summit wasn't on our agenda. Instead we went down, discovering a second rock bivvy only a few hundred metres from the one we were using. At dusk it started spitting, just as we neared our bivvy, confirming we'd made a sensible call.



James (far right) on our last abseil back to the scree fan

Next morning we took just as long as our ascent to retrace our steps back to the Landcruiser. Now the rocks were slippery and every step was a potential injury just waiting to happen. As we went, we debated about which is the best way. I'm satisfied now that staying to the true left of Cloudy Stream below about 1,000 metres is the way to go. Above that you can sidle either side of the stream, but still keeping mostly to the true left is probably best.

Ah well, another item on my unfinished business list. I don't think the southwest ridge is for me, but perhaps a winter ascent via the much easier scree fan, when covered in snow during a nice bluebird weather window would be kinda nice.

For more images and trip map – Occasionalclimber.co.nz

<http://www.occasionalclimber.co.nz/browse-images-2/new-zealand-south-island/cloudy-peak-sw-ridge-april-2016/>

A Tale of Two Peaks – Bruce and Binser

Nina Sawicki



Lorraine on the Summit of Mt. Binser

We trampers like to consider ourselves highly organized and kitted out for all manner of contingencies: emergency shelters, unanticipated map changes and medical mishaps to name but a few. One senses there may even be a brief tinge of elitism ascribed to us trampers if you take the time to read our discourses. Which of course we expect that you already do! As climbers this tinge of elitism and preparedness elevates itself to an even higher level. Well, the ground we walk upon may not at times exist or when it does it is prone to giving away and disappearing under us. So, given these high self-imposed expectations just how do we manage both our emotions and safety when these well considered contingencies fail? (which of course they ultimately will, or will they?)

So, let me present you with a scenario of two energetic eager lasses heading out for an overnight trip: our planned route being Sudden Valley Bivouac and a climb of Pyramid Peak from the head of the valley and then along the ridge. As happens quite commonly, the events of the preceding week did not set us up well for this trip. A planned departure time of 10.45 became 1.45 pm while several cups of tea were consumed debating the vicissitudes and existential trials of daily living. There was no need for panic though as we were quite capable of still reaching the bivvy by night-fall. We arrived at the sand-fly infested car park at the Hawdon Valley at about 3.00 pm. While I was hopping around with the "sand-fly dance" (an embarrassing but effective set of manoeuvres to reduce the density of sand-fly punctures to the epidermis) I struck up conversation with two young hunters who had returned from the Sudden Valley extolling its beauty and richness: (well, they had brought back several carcasses). Unfortunately, they advised that there were still several hunters well ensconced in the bivvy. No worries we thought, we had bivvy bags but unbeknown to me Lorraine was crest-fallen and had been secretly hoping to occupy the entire bivvy (well, that means a mere mattress each on the floor).

We crossed the braided river of the Hawdon and made our way up Sudden Valley with a very quiet, subdued Lorraine holding close her inner disappointment. Some moments later, the quiet

rustle of the wind down the valley and the gentle murmur of the distant river was broken with four brutal words. "I forgot the stove ". There were a few moments of silence and some unspoken thoughts. For those of you who have ever tramped with me, endless cups of tea are a non negotiable requirement of any trip. We considered all the ramifications: no hot tea, cold raw vegetables and dry pasta and porridge. We considered borrowing a stove from the ensconced hunters but that may have meant a combined "stove + pot system" and for vegetarian Lorraine the prospect of mushrooms tinged with the aroma of venison was not particularly appealing. Our mood could be described at a rather low ebb.

Some 40 minutes later, we reached the base of Sugarloaf Peak as our next intended objective. We thought that we could climb this and spend the night at Arthurs Pass in Kennedy Lodge using the stove there for our evening meal. We crossed the railway line and noted not only the presence of the Canterbury University Research Station but several cars in attendance. However, there were also several large signs indicating that we were not, in fact, at all welcome. There were an additional few moments of silence and some unspoken thoughts. We decided to respect our tramping code and some forty minutes later at 4.45 we were sited at the base of the Cass-Lagoon Saddle track with the intention of climbing Mt. Bruce (before dark we hoped). Our mood at this point was rather mixed. We realized that we had forgotten lunch which was meant to have taken place during the endless cups of tea in Christchurch.

After a short snack we were away with head-torches and moved quickly through the forested lower flanks of Mt. Bruce onto the tussock face, taking in the sights of the Upper Waimakariri and the clouds scudding past the peaks of the head of the valley. When we reached the saddle, we overshot slightly into the valley as we looked for a route up to the summit (no map alas) but, yes, we were well prepared with our GPS system! Soon we were heading up the mixed tussock and scree slope to the summit of Mt. Bruce.



View from Mt Bruce across the Waimakariri

As the sun dropped, the day cooled and our sprits rose as we were rewarded with vistas of dappled flanks of peaks and the glint of the sun on the braided river bed. Snow berries proved to be a delicious hors d'oeuvre as we anticipated my lovingly prepared vegetarian meal for our supper that night.

We reached the summit at about 7.45 and after a summit pikkie we made our way across the tussock face to pick up the track on the Waimakariri side to drop back to the forest and our car (and dinner)! We entered the forest on dark and, yes, we were prepared with our head torches and by 9.30 pm were at the car anticipating the delicious meal in the comfort of Kennedy Lodge. Our arrival time at Arthurs Pass was delayed by the ongoing road works at the Pass and we were nearly taken out by a rogue vehicle not respecting the one-way system controlled by temporary lights. You must, by now, be imagining our elation as we drove up to Kennedy Lodge to prepare our meal and settle for bed. Excitedly we drove up to the lodge and bingo "all to ourselves"! There would be no need to tip toe around as I banged together my gourmet tramping feast (by now it was 10.00 pm). There was evidence of significant renovations and suspiciously a new pad and four brutal words were uttered "The code has changed ". Yes, you guessed it: there were now some significant moments of silence and many unspoken thoughts. A delicate text message at 10.30 pm to a friend indicated there had been a code change mere days before with the beta not yet distributed in the wider circle.

The trip back to Christchurch was focused on staying awake and debating endless combinations of my long awaited meal. We had to re-endure the controlled lights of road works despite the absence of any other "night owls on wheels" prowling the hills. At 12.30 I tip tiptoed round Lorraine's kitchen to make the feast (cooking is never quiet at night). As a chronic insomniac and self-confessed night owl I had been researching that delaying bed time works well, so this was an opportune time to test this theory. My next memory was Lorraine's bright chirpy morning face with tea, jam and croissants excitedly waving a trip report of the traverse of Mt. Binser at me! Yes, there was been some sort of bush bash but the trip report indicated "it was not too bad": So, yes, we were away again to tackle the traverse of Mt. Binser. Learning from the experience of the previous day we managed our departure in a timelier way.

Lorraine hypnotized herself while I drove. She needed to blot out the traumatic memories of the road works and the long wait(s) at the red lights (she had been to Arthurs Pass for the last two or, was it three, consecutive weekends)

It was hot. We started walking at about 11.30 with as much water on board as possible. We found a small babbling brook en route to the saddle so were able to drink up large and replenish our stocks. Perhaps an hour into the trip I recounted to Lorraine a historic caution about the presence of wasp nests at the Binser Saddle. (I have a wasp anaphylaxis). Being a GP, a tramper and climber, yes, I am always prepared. Four brutal words "I have no adrenaline ". Prolonged moments of silence but, this time, a spoken thought: "So, is this PLB material? ". We continued up to the saddle carefully avoiding any signs of wasp nests which, in the open beech forest, was fortunately straightforward. At the saddle we searched back and forth to find a relatively clear patch of bush to negotiate our way up just west of the saddle to the first of the three peaks: point 1753 of Mt. Binser. There was easy travel through the lower forested flanks and once onto the higher slopes we found a mixture of tussock, stable scree and a plentiful supply of snow berries. We looked across to the ridge east of the saddle which was far more eroded and rotten and decided that our route

was definitely the safer option. We crested peak 1753 taking in the stunning vistas of the Poulter River and the Poulter Range briefly before the descent down to the saddle at 1600 m.

The descent down to the saddle involved some rotten rock with mild exposure and the wind was now beginning to gain momentum as we turned to face west we could see the clouds scudding past on the westward peaks. After a snack and the addition of another layer, Lorraine virtually jogged up to peak 2 at 1831 m while I, in amazement, at the elfin figure ahead of me, used hands and feet to follow behind in a rather ungainly manner. I don't like rotten rock but it's not as if the pair of hands actually provides any greater stability! I had doubted we would complete the traverse by night-fall but once on the second peak we were committed.



Nina traversing

From peak 1831 we began to convince ourselves we could see a vague route off the main peak of Binser 1860 m. The trip report had mentioned it was "not too bad" as a bush bash but what this actually meant was rather unclear as was our hope that we would regain the Mount White Road before night fall. From the summit of Binser (now 6.00pm) we assessed all options and judged that the route via the south-west ridge, (points 1524 and 1385) while of gentler descent and providing more open travel, would probably take too long so we opted to descend the steeper west facing ridge. After negotiating steep loose scree, a few rotten gendarmes, endless rocks in our shoes, the occasional buttock glissade, monkey tree swings we eventually spied that the last part of our descent took us into a deep gully with windfall and, yes, endless wasp nests hiding in the rich melee of the beech mold litter.



Descending off Mt. Binser into wasp country

Lorraine, ahead of me for most of this last part of the descent had been yelling out in a most unladylike fashion. I thought she had descended into obscenities but had not appreciated that she was in fact warning me to avoid the wasp nests. I was quite relieved not to have understood her windblown speech else I may have frozen solid and be there still today. It was difficult to avoid the wasps but some sixty minutes later we popped out at the top of the gully and saw that only sheep lay between us and the Mt. White Road. Miraculously, neither of us had been stung. In addition, we noted that the route to the climbers left had ended in a bluff (not marked on the map).

Our last 5 km walk back on Mt. White Road to our vehicle was spectacular; the setting sun casting glints of light on the braided strands of the Waimakariri River like nuggets for the historic diggers of old. Our gold was of a different "genre" but we may add a stove, some adrenaline and an updated door code onto our next trip.

Entranced by the Eiger

Nigel Roberts

When Daniel Joll spoke to the Wellington section of the Alpine Club on Wednesday evening, 4 May, about some of the climbs he'd done in France, Italy, and Switzerland, he gave us a modest – almost self-effacing – account of scaling the North Face of the Eiger. About six months ago, he and his climbing partner, Chaz, climbed the original 1938 route in what Daniel described as “two moderate days of climbing.”

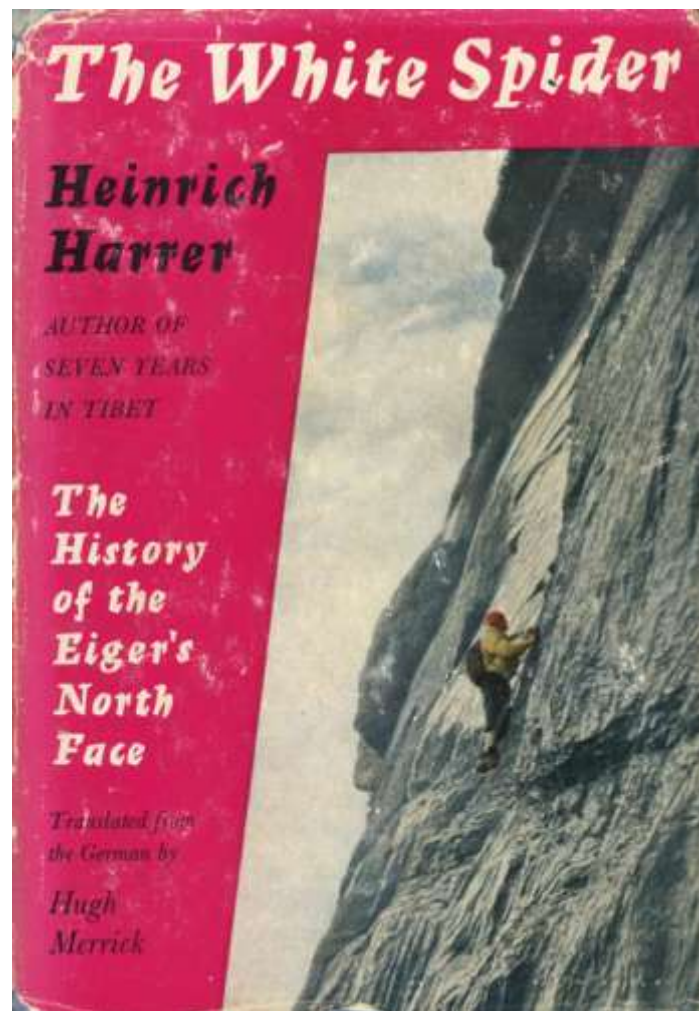
Daniel added, though, that “a fast and light team would have no problems climbing the route in less than a day in winter if the conditions are good.”

As a mountain, the Eiger is well-named: it translates as the Ogre. Although I have been entranced by the Eiger for more than half a century, I couldn't remember how long the first four climbers had taken to make their 1938 ascent of the North Face, so after his talk I asked Daniel if he knew how long the first ascent had taken. He said he didn't know, so I promised I'd go home and re-read *The White Spider* – which is precisely what I did.

For those who don't know it, *The White Spider* is a climbing classic. It was published in German in 1958 and in English the following year. The author was Heinrich Harrer, whom I initially knew as the author of *Seven Years in Tibet* – another classic (so much so that it was one of the set texts I had to study for my 1961 matriculation exams). When I first read Harrer's *Seven Years in Tibet*, however, I was utterly unaware of the fact that he'd been a member of the four-man team that had successfully completed the first ascent of the North Face of the Eiger in July 1938.

The book's title stems from a spider-shaped icefield high on the North Face. Die weisse spinne funnels ice- and rock-avalanches from all directions at climbers as they try to complete the final third of the climb.

I well recall going into town one day during the December 1960 Christmas holidays and buying *The White Spider* by Heinrich Harrer. It cost me £1.10.0 (or, as it says on the inside flap of the front cover, 30 shillings). In modern terms that's three dollars – but 30 shillings was a small fortune in the fourth quarter of 1960: it was the equivalent of \$128.30 in 2016!



The cover of Nigel Roberts' copy of The White Spider.

When I got home, I went into my bedroom and read the whole book from cover-to-cover in one fell swoop. At dinner my mother asked me what I'd been doing, and when I told her I had finished reading the book I'd bought that morning, she was horrified (and not a little angry). "What a waste of money!", she exclaimed. My mother died in 2003, but I like to think she'd have changed her mind if she knew that I still have and still treasure *The White Spider*.

In the years prior to the start of World War II, the North Face of the Eiger – the Nordwand – was widely regarded as the last great unclimbed route in the Alps. Climbers and the public alike regarded the Nordwand with a fascination akin to the mystique surrounding the Matterhorn prior to its first successful ascent by Edward Whymper and his party in 1865. The first serious attempts to climb the North Face of the Eiger were unparalleled disasters: a two-man August 1935 party froze to death in the middle of the Face at what's now known as Death Bivouac; and all four members of a July 1936 team were killed while attempting to retreat down the Face. The Nordwand acquired a morbid nickname: Mordwand (i.e., Murder Wall).

In July 1938, however, two teams met on the Face: the day after two Austrians, Heinrich Harrer and Fritz Kasperek, began climbing the North Face, two young Germans – Andreas Heckmair and Ludwig Vörg – caught up with them between the Second and Third Icefields, and (as Harrer describes it) "the result of the encounter was neither discord nor rivalry, but a teaming up."



*A postcard illustrating some of the routes up the North Face of the Eiger.
The solid red line shows the route of the first successful ascent in 1938,
which was also Daniel Joll's route.*

Despite experiencing a fall, an avalanche, and a storm ("a violent, noisy downpour" that rendered "the whole breadth of the North Face ... one fearsome waterfall"), they reached the summit of the mountain at 3:30 pm on 24 July 1938, after Harrer and Kasperek had been on the North Face for

85 hours and Heckmair and Vörg had been on it for 61 hours. The Austrians had had to bivouac three times, the Germans twice.

Taped inside the back pages of my copy of *The White Spider* are a series of clippings from newspapers around the world. They contain stories about the Eiger that were published after I bought Harrer's book. A March 1961 article in the *Johannesburg Star* is about the first successful winter ascent of the Nordwand; a clipping from the *London Evening News* dated 3 August 1963 is headlined "Eiger Beaten Solo For First Time"; and an 8 January 1964 *Hobart Mercury* article tells the story of "three young Swiss alpinists [who] recently completed the first climb down the north wall of the Eiger".

In 1963 I was lucky enough to be lent my grandmother's three-wheel Heinkel bubble-car. I drove to Dover, where I caught a cross-channel ferry to Ostend, and then spent two months travelling round "the continent" (as the English referred to Europe in those pre-EU days). Four days later – on Thursday, 22 August 1963 – I arrived in Grindelwald, at the foot of the North Face of the Eiger, to pay homage to the mountain and the mountaineers who'd climbed the Nordwand. A picture of my miniscule car and the massive mountain are an amusing memento of the occasion.



Nigel Roberts' (well, actually his grandmother's) bubble-car below the North Face of the Eiger in August 1963.

Forty-one years later, three of us – Caroline Ogden, Eric Hodge, and I – fresh from success on Mt Blanc, arrived in Switzerland hoping to climb the Eiger: not via the North Face, I hasten to add, but via the Mittellegi Ridge. However, the weather in the Bernese Oberland was dreadful, so we retreated to a lovely little village called Saas-Grund, in a valley immediately to the east of the Matterhorn and, as a consolation prize, I climbed Allalinhorn (4,027 metres) instead. Given that we rode via cable-car and train up to 3,500 metres, it was probably the easiest 4,000-metre peak I've ever climbed.



Nigel Roberts on the summit of Allalinhorn, a 4,000-metre peak in Switzerland that he climbed in August 2004 instead of the Eiger.

Ironically, though, the Eiger is not a 4,000-metre peak: its summit is "only" 3,970 metres above sea-level. However, that just goes to show that size isn't everything. The Eiger is a mighty mountain, and its North Face is justly both famous and infamous. I salute Daniel Joll; I'm in awe of his and Chaz's achievement.

Notices

INFORMATION PLEASE

Does anyone know the name of a mountain in Sikkim about 40 km (25 – 30 miles) north of the city previously called Darjeeling? It has a Buddhist pilgrimage place in a cave on scree on its slopes called something like Lariong Fook. My grandpa, Dr Joubert, and another man called Tanner(?) tried to climb it about 1883.

If you have information please reply to Anne, amarch08@gmail.com

Remarkable's Mixed and Ice Festival Trip - Thursday 25 to Tuesday 30 August inclusive.

Jenny Cossey (Wellington Member) is organising a private trip to the Remarkable's Mixed and Ice Festival 2016. **This is not a supported NZAC Wellington Section or National Trip.** If you would like to attend with Jenny, further details are below.

This is the annual climbing meet of the Expedition Climbers Club Incorporated. Bringing together a huge cross section of climbers from around NZ and the world. Beginners get to rub shoulders and share the rope with the top winter alpine climbers in NZ. Clinics, competitions, races and social gatherings advance and promote modern mixed climbing. Showcasing the new and existing route potential on NZ's most accessible multi-pitch winter training area, the Remarkables. Sharing local knowledge and forming new climbing partnerships. Fundraising for the ECC Expedition Capital Fund.

For more information about the festival and what options are available see more at: <http://www.iceandmixedfestival.co.nz/#!/about/> . By signing up to the festival you automatically become a member of the Expedition Climbers Club to help raise funds for NZ expeditions overseas. Festival registration is now open on a first come, first serve basis. Festival registration closes three weeks prior to the festival or whenever the clinic/general climbing allocation is full.

For more information about the trip please contact Jenny Cossey.

Please confirm your Remarkable's Mixed and Ice Festival registration and Wellington to Queenstown flight tickets to trip organiser Jenny Cossey by July 31st to confirm your attendance.

Contact Jenny on jennycossey1@gmail.com 021 072 1000

NZAC 2017 Climbing Camp

The Otago Section will be hosting the 2017 climbing camp that will be from Saturday 4th to Saturday 11th February. The Camp will be based at the Top Forks Hut in the Wilkin Valley. As it is a 12 hour walk into the Top Forks hut it is proposed that people attending the camp travel by helicopter from Makarora.

Top Forks hut is in a stunning alpine environment and there are several peaks within striking distance of the hut, many of them grade 1 climbs. Campers are expected to be self-contained with their own tent, cooking equipment, fuel and food. We will have access to the hut but not exclusive use. We will be providing some basic communal facilities such as a tarp shelter, dish-washing facilities, toilet tent, thermos and a mountain radio.

We will limit the number of people attending the camp to 40 so early registration is recommended. You can obtain additional information and a registration form from the NZAC website. There will be a modest registration fee and you are expected to pay for your helicopter or jet boat travel to and from the camp. Budget on \$170 each way to/from Top Forks for the helicopter or \$110 each way for jet boat access via Kerin Forks Hut. Note: Top Forks is still a 6 hr walk from Kerin Forks. An option is to fly in and jet boat out.

The camp is suitable for climbers of all levels of experience but you must be an Alpine club member to attend. If you do not have a climbing partner at the camp we will arrange for you to team up with other climbers.

If you require additional information contact Keith Moffat Ph 03 473-8903 Mob 0276644037 or e-mail Moffat.k172@gmail.com

Wellington Section 2016 contacts list

We are always thankful for volunteers and members stepping forward to help the section run smoothly. If you'd like to learn more about how you could get involved, please email us at wellington@alpineclub.org.nz

Position	Name	Contact
Chairperson	Simon Williamson	021 054 7684
Co Chair	Eric Duggan	021 350 161
Treasurer	Mark Leslie	027 338 4458
Secretary & Vertigo editor	Carolyn Ellis	021 574 287
Patron	John Nankervis	
Other Committee Members	Aviette Musin	021 0299 5390
	Mark Johnston	027 924 4178
	Sharron Came	
	Gina Butson	
	Elisha Watson	
Rock Drill Overseer	Jeremy Tries	027 55 55 893
Any membership, Distaghil Sar Fund, or general queries should be directed to the secretary		



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